ing to the Congress. By setting off such mass attrition, the saffron party tried to weaken Kamal Nath's support base at the grassroots level, which was seen as the main factor for his son's win in 2019.

But the biggest embarrassment awaited the party in Indore, as on April 29, its candidate Akshay Kanti Bam withdrew his nomination at the eleventh hour, pushing the Congress out of the running—a first in this key constituency's electoral history. As Bam later joined the BJP, he attributed his decision to the Congress organisation's "non-cooperation" for his campaign. "The Congress has fielded some good candidates, but they are unable to gain traction among the electorate," says Bhopal-based veteran journalist N.K. Singh. "The BJP had peaked in Madhya Pradesh in the last general election. But the Congress is severely disorganised and has failed to project itself as an alternative."

In fact, the BJP's domination over the voters' minds is nearly complete in most areas. Its core Hindutva plank, bolstered by the Ram temple in Ayodhya, may not find resonance with the electorate in tribal areas, but there are several pockets where such issues have delivered for it perennially—even when not pushed aggressively. This is true especially in the case of constituencies in the Malwa and Nimar regions, such as Indore, Ujjain, Dewas, Khandwa, Khargone and Mandsaur. Needless to say, the BJP has a clear upper hand in such seats.

But despite this total domination in the battleground, some chinks in the armour are glaringly apparent. The BJP's candidate selection process for several seats seems to have disregarded track records and popularity. In Rajgarh, for instance, two-term MP Rodmal Nagar, who is pitted against former Congress chief minister Digvijaya Singh, has been facing opposition from within the ranks and is heavily banking on the



CAMPAIGN STRATEGY

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

- Turn the contest in every seat into a battle between Prime Minister Narendra Modi (and his 'guarantees') and the Congress candidate
- Trigger attrition in the Congress ranks–not just at the top but, especially, at the booth level
- Deploy the core Hindutva issues selectively in regions where they find resonance with the voters, like in Malwa

CONGRESS

- Keep the campaign candidate-specific in each seat instead of trying to take on Narendra Modi directly
- Not stretch itself too thin and focus on the 15-odd seats where the party has done well in the recent past and put up a token fight on others
- Concentrate on the tribal-dominated seats, as STs were the only group that didn't abandon the Congress in the assembly polls